# Get The Credit You're Owed

**A Practical Playbook for When Your Work Gets Stolen**

You've been there. The meeting where your manager takes your analysis, presents it as his own, and gets the nod of approval from leadership. The email thread where a colleague claims the solution you built. The casual conversation where your idea gets attributed to someone who wasn't even in the room. And the worst part isn't just the stolen credit—it's the voice in your head that starts to wonder: *Maybe I don't actually contribute that much. Maybe I'm replaceable. Maybe I imagined it.*

That doubt is the real damage. It's the residue of a situation that wasn't your fault, and it doesn't belong to you.

Here's what this guide is and isn't. It isn't about "speaking up more" or "having confidence"—that advice assumes the problem is you. It isn't about confrontation strategies designed to make enemies. And it isn't about learning to "handle it" by becoming numb to injustice.

This is about a specific, solvable problem: someone took something that was yours and presented it as theirs, and you didn't have a plan for what to do next.

Maybe you've experienced this once and it caught you completely off guard. Maybe it's a pattern—your manager has done it three times, and you're starting to feel like you can't win. Maybe you did speak up once, you were told you were being "too sensitive," and now you're afraid to say anything again.

Whatever brought you here, this guide gives you an actual playbook. You'll learn exactly how to respond in the moment, how to build a record that protects you going forward, and how to shift the power dynamic so it happens less often. The goal isn't to catch them—it's to make sure your work is clearly, unmistakably yours.

We'll start by helping you ground yourself before you do anything else. Because the worst thing you can do is respond from a place of hurt, and the second-worst thing is to do nothing while the doubt eats you alive. Between those two failures, there's a real strategy.

Let's get into it.

# Part One: Ground Yourself First

Before you send that email, schedule that conversation, or say another word about what happened—you need to pause. Not because action isn't warranted. Because action taken in a state of hurt often backfires, and right now, you're hurt.

The first three chapters are about getting clear before you get loud. They're about separating what happened from what you think it means about you. And they're about choosing the right response for your specific situation instead of either exploding or swallowing it whole.

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## Chapter 1: Confirm It Actually Happened

This sounds ridiculous, I know. You know what happened. But here's what I've learned from working with people through this: not every situation that *feels* like credit theft actually is credit theft—and acting like it is, when it isn't, will undermine your credibility for the times when it really is.

Here's what I mean. In most workplaces, ideas are collaborative. Someone mentions something in passing, you riff on it, someone else builds on top, and six months later nobody can remember who thought of what. That's not theft. That's just how work works.

Credit theft is different. Credit theft is when your *specific contribution*—the analysis you ran, the code you wrote, the solution you designed—is presented as if someone else did it. It's not "we built this together." It's "I built this."

**The Three Questions That Determine If It Was Theft**

Before you do anything else, ask yourself these three questions honestly:

**Question 1: What exactly was said?** Not what you interpreted, not the tone, not what you assume the person was thinking. What were the actual words? "Great work on this analysis" can feel like theft if you were hoping for "great work on *your* analysis"—but those are different things.

**Question 2: What exactly was yours?** Be specific. Did you write the deck from scratch? Or did you contribute data that someone else synthesized? Did you have the original insight, or were you one of three people who landed on the same conclusion? The vaguer your contribution, the harder it is to make a case.

**Question 3: Did intent appear to be present?** This one matters less for your response (intent is hard to prove), but it matters for your emotional processing. A manager who forgot you were in the meeting is annoying. A manager who knew you were there and deliberately omitted your name is something different. Separating these doesn't mean you should accept either—but it does mean you shouldn't treat them identically.

### The Credit Audit Worksheet

Find a quiet moment and answer these questions in writing:

1. What happened? (Use only facts—no interpretations)
2. What was my specific contribution? (Be as concrete as possible)
3. Was this a collaborative situation where mixed credit is normal, or was this clearly my work being claimed by someone else?
4. What did I assume the other person's intent was? Is that assumption based on evidence or on how I feel right now?
5. Have I experienced similar situations with this person before, or is this a pattern I'm noticing for the first time?
6. On a scale of 1-10, how significant is this? (10 = career-affecting; 1 = annoying but minor)

If after completing this worksheet, you've landed on "yes, this was actually theft" and the score is above a 4 or 5, you have legitimate ground to stand on. If you're still uncertain, give yourself 24 hours. Often, clarity comes once the initial sting fades.

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Write out the three questions above and answer them honestly
- [ ] Complete the Credit Audit Worksheet in writing (even if just for yourself)
- [ ] Identify one thing you know for certain was your work that nobody can dispute (this will be your anchor)

# Chapter 2: Disentangle Your Contribution from Your Doubt

Here's the cruelest part of credit theft: it doesn't just steal your work. It plants seeds of doubt that spread into everything else.

You start questioning whether you actually contributed. Whether you were just "along for the ride." Whether you're good enough to deserve your job in the first place. And once that doubt takes root, it doesn't stay in one place—it contaminates your confidence at work, and then it starts leaking into your life outside of work.

You need to separate these two things right now. The practical problem (someone misrepresented your work) and the psychological problem (you're now doubting your own value) are two separate problems. This chapter is about the psychological one, because if you don't address it, you'll make bad decisions about the practical one.

### Why the Doubt Doesn't Belong to You

When your work gets stolen, your brain does something predictable: it flips the narrative. Instead of "someone did something wrong to me," it shifts to "there must be something wrong with me, or this wouldn't keep happening."

This is a distortion. It's also incredibly common—and it's worth naming it for what it is. The doubt is *damage*. It's the residue of someone treating you unfairly, not evidence of your inadequacy.

Here's a reframe that helps: Think about the last time you were genuinely, objectively excellent at something. Not when someone told you were, but when you *knew* you were. Maybe it was a project that went smoothly. Maybe it was a moment when you saved the day. Maybe it was just a Tuesday when you knocked out a bunch of tasks and did them well.

Did you need someone else to confirm that happened for you to know it did? Probably not. You knew because you were there. You knew because you did the work.

That knowledge is still true. Someone else claiming credit for it doesn't erase the reality of it.

### The Evidence Inventory

Here's a concrete exercise. Set a timer for 15 minutes and write down everything you've contributed in the past six months that you can document in some way. I'm not talking about credit that was given or recognition that came. I'm talking about work that exists in some form:

- Emails you sent with specific proposals
- Documents you created that still exist
- Projects you drove that had outcomes
- Problems you solved that nobody else was solving
- Decisions you influenced with your analysis

The goal isn't to build a case for a specific incident. The goal is to remind yourself—and this is key—of who you actually are.

Because here's the trap: when credit theft happens, it feels like it erases you. The Evidence Inventory is your counterbalance. It's proof that you exist, that you contribute, that you matter. And when that voice in your head says "maybe I didn't actually do that much," you have something to point to.

### Separating "What Happened" from "What It Means"

One more reframe before we move on. Right now, your brain is probably linking three things that don't actually need to be linked:

- Someone misrepresented my work
- They must have done it deliberately
- Therefore, I must not actually be valuable

None of these three statements logically leads to the others. The only thing you know for certain is the first one. The second is an assumption. The third is damage.

Your task right now is to stop the chain. You can be angry about what happened. You can be determined to address it. But you don't have to let it rewrite the story of who you are.

### Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Complete the Evidence Inventory for the past six months
- [ ] Write out the three-link chain above and consciously interrupt it
- [ ] Identify one moment in the past month when you know—*know*—you did solid work (no external validation required)

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## Chapter 3: Determine the Response Threshold

Now you've confirmed it happened, and you've started disentangling the facts from the doubt. The next question is: what do you actually do about it?

Here's where people make expensive mistakes. They either under-respond (do nothing because they're afraid) or over-respond (fire off an angry email that makes things worse). The goal is to respond *correctly*—and "correctly" depends on four factors.

#### The Four Factors That Should Determine Your Response

#### Factor 1: The Stakes

How much does this actually matter? A manager claiming your slide in a one-off meeting is annoying but might not be worth a confrontation. A pattern where your work is consistently attributed to a competitor—someone who is also being considered for promotion—might be worth escalated action. Ask yourself: What are the real-world consequences if nothing changes?

#### Factor 2: The Relationship

Is this someone you have an ongoing relationship with? A one-time offender who's otherwise reasonable might respond well to a direct, private conversation. Someone who has a pattern of credit theft, or who holds power over your career, requires a different approach. The closer the relationship and the more ongoing contact you'll have, the more you need to think about how your response affects that dynamic.

### Factor 3: Your Power Position

This one's hard to hear but important: if you're early in your career, the person taking credit is more senior than you, and you don't have allies yet, your options are more limited. That's not fair. It's also not changeable in the next 24 hours. Strategic response means working within your actual situation, not your ideal one. As you build visibility and allies over time, your power position improves.

### Factor 4: Pattern vs. Isolated Incident

A one-time situation calls for a direct conversation. A pattern of behavior requires documentation and a different kind of response. If this is the third or fourth time with the same person, you can't treat it like a miscommunication that needs correcting. You need to treat it like a pattern that needs addressing.

### The Response Decision Matrix

Based on these four factors, here's how to think about which path to take:

- **Immediate direct conversation** makes sense when: stakes are moderate to high, you have an ongoing relationship with this person, you have enough standing that they'll take you seriously, and this is isolated (or the first of a pattern).
- **Documentation and strategic patience** makes sense when: stakes are high, the relationship is complicated, your power position is weak, and this is part of a larger pattern. You're not ignoring it—you're building a case.
- **Escalation or formal response** makes sense when: the stakes are very high (career-affecting), the behavior is a clear pattern, you've tried direct approaches, and you have support or evidence.

Most readers of this guide will be in the first or second category. The third is important to know about, but it's not the first move.

### One Thing You're Not Doing: Nothing Because You're Afraid

I want to be direct about this. "Strategic non-response" and "doing nothing because you're afraid" are not the same thing. One is a deliberate choice based on analysis. The other is freeze—your nervous system protecting you from perceived danger.

If you're not responding because you're afraid of making things worse, or afraid of being labeled difficult, or afraid of the confrontation itself—that's fear, not strategy. And fear-based inaction almost always turns into resentment, which turns into burnout, which turns into you leaving a job you otherwise like.

The difference: strategy has a plan. Fear just has avoidance.

So before you choose your path, check in with yourself honestly. Is this a strategic choice? Or is this fear wearing strategy's clothes?

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Score your situation on all four factors (stakes, relationship, power position, pattern)
- [ ] Determine which response path matches your situation
- [ ] If you're choosing "strategic patience," write down what documentation you're building and what your timeline is

### Key Takeaway for Part One

Ground yourself before you act. Confirm what actually happened, separate the facts from the doubt, and choose your response based on the actual situation—not the emotional spike. The goal is to respond effectively, not to react impulsively or collapse entirely.

# Part Two: Immediate Response Tactics

You're grounded. You know what happened, you've separated the facts from the damage, and you have a sense of what response is appropriate. Now comes the part you came here for: what do you actually say?

This part covers three scenarios. The moment it happens (Chapter 4). The 24 hours after (Chapter 5). And the times when your best move is to let it go—but to do that from a place of power, not fear (Chapter 6).

## Chapter 4: The In-the-Moment Recovery

Credit theft is disorienting. In the moment, you often don't know what to say, so you say nothing. Then the meeting ends, the email goes out, the decision gets made—and you're left staring at the aftermath, wishing you'd found the words.

The goal of this chapter isn't to make you witty or quick. It's to give you a framework that works even when you're caught off guard. Three moves. Practice these, and you won't be caught empty-handed.

**The Three-Part Verbal Recovery Framework**

**Move 1: Acknowledge without attacking**

Start by giving the other person the benefit of the doubt on intent while still reestablishing the facts. You're not accusing, you're clarifying.

- "Just to be clear, happy to help with any questions on the methodology—that was something I worked on."
- "Yeah, we put a lot of time into this one. Happy to walk through the details."
- "That analysis drew on the data team work Sarah and I did last quarter, if that's useful context."

Notice what's happening here: you're not saying "you took my credit." You're not making it adversarial. You're simply inserting yourself into a story where you were already present.

#### Move 2: Reestablish without appearing defensive

The fear with speaking up is that you'll look defensive or petty. The way to avoid that is to keep the tone collaborative and the focus forward-looking.

- "I'd love to make sure credit flows properly here—I was part of this work."
- "For what it's worth, I had visibility into this piece and happy to provide more detail."
- "Just want to make sure the record reflects the team's work here."

The key is framing it as "making sure the record is accurate" rather than "you just took my credit." You're positioning yourself as someone who cares about clarity, not someone making accusations.

#### Move 3: Redirect without escalating

If the conversation is moving past the point where reestablishing makes sense, pivot to next steps. This shows you're not trying to create conflict—you're focused on moving forward.

- "Anyway, the key thing now is getting this implemented—I've got the next steps drafted if that's helpful."
- "Happy to take this offline and walk through the specifics—let's make sure we get the approach right."
- "The critical path here is X. I can own that piece if it makes sense."

### Four Common Scenarios and How to Handle Them

#### Scenario 1: Your manager claims your work in a meeting

This is the hardest one because of the power dynamic. Your best move is usually Move 1 or 2, done once, lightly. Then follow up in writing within 24 hours (we'll cover that in the next chapter).

In the meeting: "Happy to dig into the details on this—happy to walk through the approach I took." (Don't say "my approach" or it sounds accusatory. Say "the approach I took" as fact.)

**Scenario 2: A colleague takes credit in an email**

This one is easier because there's a written record. In the email: "Great synthesis—want to make sure the record reflects the earlier analysis [link] that informed this. Always happy to add more context if useful."

Keep it collaborative. Frame it as adding to, not correcting.

**Scenario 3: A peer claims your solution in front of leadership**

Use the three moves quickly and move on. In the moment: "That's right—we've been building toward that. Happy to share the work we've done." Then pivot to next steps.

If they keep going, a light version of Move 3: "The implementation piece is where we've been focused—I can take that on if it helps."

**Scenario 4: Verbal idea theft in a brainstorm**

Often the most diffuse and hardest to address. In the moment: "Yeah, I was thinking along similar lines when I was working on [project]. Want me to walk through what I found?"

If the idea gets attributed to someone else without correction: "Just to add—I actually mentioned something similar in our [previous meeting]. Want me to pull up what I shared?"

**Recovery Phrase Bank**

Keep a set of phrases you can use in your back pocket. Write down three or four that feel natural to you, practice saying them out loud, and you'll be ready when it happens.

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Review the three-part framework and practice the moves in the mirror
- [ ] Choose the scenario that most closely matches your situation
- [ ] Draft your personalized recovery phrase using the templates above

- [ ] Practice saying it out loud until it feels natural

## Chapter 5: The 24-Hour Follow-Up

What you do in the 24 hours after a credit theft matters more than you probably think. This is where you either let it fester (and it will) or you create a record.

I'm not talking about building a legal case. I'm talking about the email that says, "As discussed, happy to continue driving the X initiative," or the Slack message that references, "The analysis we pulled together last week." These aren't suspicious—they're normal. But they do one thing crucial: they put your involvement in writing.

### What to Send in the 24 Hours After

The goal isn't confrontation. The goal is documentation that is also relationship-preserving. Three things to include in your follow-up:

**1. A factual restatement of your involvement**

This is not accusatory. It's a simple clarification that can be referenced later if needed.

"As a follow-up to today's meeting, I wanted to make sure I captured my role here. I led the data analysis that informed the deck, and I've been supporting the implementation planning as well. Happy to keep driving the execution piece if that works for the team."

Notice what's happening: you're stating facts in a collaborative tone. You're not saying "you claimed my work." You're saying what you did, plainly.

**2. A forward-looking offer that reestablishes your ongoing role**

The person who took credit probably wants to move on and not think about it. The best way to prevent repeat behavior is to reestablish yourself as the ongoing owner.

"For the next phase, I've got the implementation outline drafted—I can have it ready for review by Thursday. Let me know if you want me to schedule a walkthrough."

#### 3. A CC or documentation touch

If there are other people in the loop who should know about your involvement, it's reasonable to loop them in—collaboratively. "FYI, sharing the planning doc here as a reference for anyone who wants to dig into the methodology."

This is not aggressive. It's transparency. And it makes it much harder for credit theft to become a pattern.

### What NOT to Send

- Angry emails
- Emails that call out the other person by name or accuse them
- Passive-aggressive emails that hint without saying
- Emails that vent or ask for validation from uninvolved colleagues

The goal is to be the person who handles things professionally while also being the person who maintains a clear, factual record. That's the person who wins over time.

### Follow-Up Email Templates

Use these as starting points. Adapt them to your voice, your situation, and the relationship you have with the person involved.

For a manager claiming your work:

> "Thanks for leading the presentation today—I wanted to make sure my contribution was captured as well. I led the data analysis and put together the methodology section. Happy to continue owning this workstream if that makes sense—I've got the next phase drafted and can have it ready for review."

For a colleague claiming your work in a group setting:

> "Wanted to follow up after our discussion. I wanted to make sure the context was clear—I was the one who pulled together the initial analysis that informed this direction. I'm set up to keep driving the implementation piece if that works."

For a peer claiming your solution:

> "Following up on what came up in the meeting—I want to make sure the record reflects that this solution was the result of work I've been leading. Happy to share the methodology doc and walk through the approach in more detail."

### Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Identify which template matches your situation
- [ ] Draft your follow-up email using the template as a starting point
- [ ] Review it one more time to remove any accusatory language
- [ ] Send it within 24 hours—don't let it sit longer

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## Chapter 6: When to Let It Go—Strategically

Here's the thing nobody tells you: sometimes the right response to credit theft is to let it go. And this is only a good thing if you're doing it strategically—not because you're afraid, not because you're exhausted, and not because you've decided your work doesn't matter.

Strategic non-response is a tool. It requires clarity, not defeat.

**The Difference Between Strategic and Fear-Based Non-Response**

Strategic non-response means: You've assessed the situation, determined that the response cost (relationship damage, political risk, energy spent) outweighs the benefit, and made a conscious choice to let it pass.

Fear-based non-response means: You're not responding because you're afraid of confrontation, afraid of being seen as difficult, or afraid that speaking up will make things worse.

The test: Is there a plan behind the non-response, or is there just avoidance?

Strategic non-response usually has these elements:

- You've decided the stakes are low enough that it's not worth the energy
- You're choosing your battles deliberately, not because you're backed into a corner
- You have a plan for preventing it from becoming a pattern (more on that in Part Three)
- You're not carrying resentment as a result—you've genuinely let it go

If you can't check those boxes, you're not being strategic. You're just scared.

**The Strategic Non-Response Framework**

Before you choose non-response, ask yourself these questions:

1. **What's the actual cost of the theft?** (Financial, career, reputational)
2. **What's the cost of responding?** (Relationship damage, political capital, time)
3. **Is this a one-time incident or part of a pattern?** (If pattern, non-response is more risky)
4. **Do I have the emotional bandwidth to respond right now?** (If not, wait until you do—but don't use this as permanent excuse)
5. **What's my plan for preventing this in the future?** (If you don't have one, non-response without a prevention plan is just hoping it won't happen again)

If you've answered these honestly and landed on non-response, here's the crucial step: let it actually go. That means the thoughts about it stop. The replaying stops. The resentment stops.

If you can't let it go, you haven't actually made the strategic choice. You've just delayed the reckoning.

### Releasing the Mental Load

Here's what actually works: When you choose strategic non-response, write it down. Literally write: "I am choosing not to respond to X because Y (the cost outweighs the benefit). I release this mentally and will not revisit it unless it happens again."

Then do something physical—go for a walk, hit the gym, cook something. Get it out of your head and into your body. The goal is to genuinely move on, not to rehearse the confrontation you'll never have.

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Complete the Strategic Non-Response Framework in writing
- [ ] If you're choosing non-response, write the release statement literally
- [ ] Do one physical activity to help move the emotional energy through
- [ ] Schedule a prevention check-in with yourself (weekly for the next month)

### Key Takeaway for Part Two

Respond in the moment, document in writing, and only let it go when you've made a deliberate choice to do so. The goal is to be the person who handles credit theft professionally, factually, and strategically—not the person who explodes, disappears, or carries resentment forever.

# Part Three: Building the Proof

Response tactics handle the incident. But if you've been through credit theft once, you know: the real issue is often the pattern. And patterns don't get prevented by reacting—they get prevented by building systems.

This part is about creating visibility, documentation, and infrastructure around your work so that credit theft becomes harder to happen and easier to prove when it does.

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## Chapter 7: Documenting Without Being Obvious About It

The instinct is either to over-document (sending constant "I did this" updates that feel desperate) or to under-document (letting your work float freely without any anchor). Neither serves you.

The goal is to create a documentation habit that is normal, professional, and useful—and that just happens to make credit theft much more difficult.

#### The Five-Point Documentation Habit

#### Point 1: Email yourself the work immediately

When you complete something significant—write it down, email it to yourself with a timestamp. This creates an independent record of your involvement. "Analysis complete: [date]. Methodology: [details]. Conclusions: [summary]."

This isn't suspicious. It's just good note-taking. And it exists outside the official system.

#### Point 2: Send "FYI" updates, not "Look what I did" updates

There's a way to keep people informed that doesn't sound like you're building a case:

- "Quick update—finished the analysis on X. Key finding is [summary]. Sharing doc with the team for review."

- "Just finished the first draft of Y. Main sections are [list]. Happy to walk through if useful."

The difference: you're providing information, not asking for credit. But you're also putting your involvement in writing.

**Point 3: Reference past work when relevant**

When a new project comes up, reference your prior work naturally:

- "Building on the framework we established in [previous project], here's how I'm applying it here."
- "Based on the data analysis we completed in Q2, I'm projecting [conclusion] for this initiative."

This does two things: it reminds people of your past contribution, and it establishes your ongoing ownership.

**Point 4: Use project management tools and tagging**

If your team uses Asana, Jira, Trello, or any project management tool, make sure your name is on your contributions. Tag yourself, log your hours, add comments. This creates an automatic record that nobody controls except you.

**Point 5: Keep a personal work log**

This is just for you—a running document of what you did, when, and what came of it. Review it monthly. This is your personal evidence inventory, and it will serve you in performance reviews, when seeking opportunities, and yes, when proving credit theft happened.

**The Documentation Conversation**

If you're in a meeting and someone asks who did something, or who was responsible for a particular outcome, it's completely reasonable to say:

"Just to keep the record clear—I was the one who led that piece. Happy to provide more detail."

You don't have to be defensive about it. You're just maintaining accuracy.

### Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Send yourself an email documenting one significant recent contribution
- [ ] Start a personal work log (even a simple document)
- [ ] Review your last three significant projects and check: is there a record of your involvement anywhere?
- [ ] Identify one project management tool you could use better to document your work

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## Chapter 8: Building Visibility Across Your Organization

Credit theft often happens because you're not visible enough. It's not malicious—it's just that when people don't see you doing the work, they assume someone else did it.

Visibility isn't about being loud or showy. It's about making sure that the people who make decisions know who you are and what you contribute.

**The Three-Layer Visibility Strategy**

**Layer 1: Your direct manager**

This is table stakes. Your manager should know what you're working on, what you've contributed, and what you're capable of. Not in a way that feels like you're reporting every move, but in a way that ensures they can advocate for you when you're not in the room.

Monthly check-ins work well. A simple: "Here's what I've been working on, here are the results, here's what I'm planning next." Keep it concise, keep it consistent.

**Layer 2: Your broader organization**

This is where people go wrong. They assume that if their manager knows, everyone knows. But credit theft often comes from people outside your immediate team—people who have no visibility into what you do day to day.

Find ways to make your work visible to stakeholders who matter:

- Share project summaries in team channels
- Volunteer to present your work in larger meetings
- Contribute to org-wide communications or knowledge bases
- Offer to help on cross-functional projects where you'll be seen by new people

The goal is to build a reputation that precedes you. When people hear your name, they should connect it with specific, valuable work —not just a vague sense that you exist.

**Layer 3: Your sponsors and allies**

Visibility without advocacy is incomplete. You need people in your organization who will speak for you when you're not in the room—people who will say, "Oh, that's actually X's area," or, "I know the work behind this, and it was solid."

Sponsors aren't the same as managers. They're usually more senior, they've chosen to advocate for you, and they have enough visibility to make your name known in rooms you don't occupy.

How to build sponsors:

- Do great work that gets noticed
- Show genuine interest in their success, not just what they can do for you
- Be someone worth advocating for (reliable, good judgment, easy to work with)
- Ask for advice or mentorship—these are low-stakes ways to build the relationship

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Schedule your next monthly check-in with your manager (if you don't have one, propose one)

- [ ] Identify one stakeholder outside your team who should know what you're working on
- [ ] Choose one visibility action for the next two weeks (present at a meeting, share a project summary, volunteer for a cross-functional initiative)
- [ ] Identify one person who might become a sponsor and find a natural way to connect

## Chapter 9: Creating a Paper Trail That Protects You

This is the last line of defense. Not the first move, but the one that matters if things go sideways.

A paper trail isn't about paranoia. It's about having evidence that exists independently of any one person's memory. And in any organization, memory is fragile and politically motivated.

### What to Keep and Where

**Official channels:** Keep copies of any work-related communications, project documentation, emails, Slack threads, presentations. These should be stored somewhere you control—not just in a shared drive that someone else administers.

**Timestamps matter:** If you create something, make sure it has your name on it and a creation date. This is basic, but it matters.

**Communication records:** If you have a conversation about credit or contributions, follow up in writing: "As we discussed, just confirming that I'll be leading X. Let me know if anything changes." This creates a record.

**Witnesses:** In some situations, having someone else aware of your work is its own protection. Not in a gossipy way, but in a "this is a cross-functional project and my colleague from another team was there" kind of way.

### The Paper Trail Checklist

- [ ] You have copies of all significant project documents stored somewhere you control
- [ ] Your work has your name on it (in the file metadata if not the content)
- [ ] You've followed up verbal conversations with written summaries
- [ ] You have at least one person besides your manager who can testify to your contributions
- [ ] Your personal work log is current and backed up

### When to Use the Paper Trail

This is not ammunition to be brandished. This is protection to be deployed only when needed—and only strategically.

If you've had direct conversations, documented in writing, and the behavior continues, that's when the paper trail matters. If you're in a performance review and someone questions your contributions, that's when you reference it. If you need to escalate formally, that's when the paper trail becomes essential.

Until then, let it sit. The goal isn't to build a case against anyone. It's to make sure that if the situation requires it, you have the evidence to support your claims.

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Review your paper trail checklist
- [ ] Identify any gaps (missing documentation, no witnesses, no personal record)
- [ ] Back up one important piece of documentation today
- [ ] Consider: if someone tried to claim your most significant recent project, do you have proof?

### Key Takeaway for Part Three

Build systems that make credit theft harder. Document your work normally and professionally. Create visibility across your organization—not just for credit, but so your work actually reaches the people who need it. And maintain a paper trail that protects you without being paranoid about it.

# Part Four: Long-Term Strategy

We've covered how to respond in the moment and how to build systems that prevent problems. But here's what I've learned from watching people navigate this over time: the most powerful move isn't tactical. It's strategic.

Long-term, your goal isn't to catch every person who takes your credit. It's to shift the dynamics so that your work is visible, your contributions are known, and your standing in the organization makes credit theft both unlikely and costly.

This part covers the shifts that matter most.

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## Chapter 10: Shifting the Power Dynamic

Credit theft is a power issue as much as it is a recognition issue. People take credit from those they think they can take it from. That's not justification—it's the dynamic you need to understand.

The solution isn't confrontation. It's changing the equation.

### The Power Equation

Power in an organization flows from three sources:

1. **Visibility:** Who knows what you do?
2. **Relationships:** Who will vouch for you?
3. **Results:** What outcomes are attached to your name?

If any of these three is strong, you're harder to ignore. If all three are strong, you're very difficult to steal from.

### Building Each Source

**Visibility:** We've covered this. Make sure that at least three levels above you, people know your name and associate it with valuable work. This isn't vanity—it's infrastructure.

**Relationships:** Build genuine relationships with people across the organization—not just for instrumental purposes, but because they're good people and you genuinely value them. When those people see your work being claimed, they'll correct it without being asked. That's not networking. That's friendship with professional upside.

**Results:** Track outcomes, not just activities. "I worked on that" is forgettable. "The initiative I led increased efficiency by 20%" is not. Learn to attach numbers and results to your contributions, and make sure those results are known.

### The Reputation Dividend

Here's what happens when you build these three sources: your reputation becomes its own protection. People who know you and value you are less likely to take your credit—and if they do, there are people around who will notice and correct it.

This isn't instant. But it's the long game that wins.

## Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Assess your power equation: where are you strong? Where are you weak?
- [ ] Identify one action to increase visibility, one to deepen a relationship, and one to connect your work to outcomes
- [ ] Find one person in your organization who doesn't know you well and introduce yourself

## Chapter 11: Knowing When to Escalate

Most credit theft doesn't require formal escalation. A direct conversation, a written follow-up, and strategic visibility are enough. But sometimes they're not.

Here are the indicators that escalation may be warranted:

**Indicators that escalation is warranted:**

- This is a clear pattern with significant career impact
- Direct conversations have been attempted and ignored
- You've documented the incidents and have evidence
- The person holding your credit is doing so deliberately and repeatedly
- There's a power imbalance that's being actively used against you
- You're experiencing retaliation after attempting to address it

**Escalation paths (in order of intensity):**

1. **Documented conversation with HR:** Not as a complaint, but as a pattern you want on record. Frame it as seeking support, not attacking someone.

2. **Formal documentation:** If HR is involved, put it in writing. Stick to facts. "On dates X, Y, and Z, my work was presented as belonging to [person]. I addressed this directly on [dates]. The behavior continues."

3. **Involving sponsors or advocates:** If you have sponsors, now is the time to ask for their support. A senior person saying "I know this work and it was X's" carries weight.

4. **Formal HR complaint:** If other paths have failed and the impact is significant, this is the path. Document everything first. Make sure you understand your company's policies. Go in with facts, not emotions.

**What escalation is not:**

Escalation is not revenge. It's not punishment. It's a serious response to a serious pattern. If you escalate out of anger, it will backfire. If you escalate out of genuine concern for fairness and your career, it has a better chance of working.

Escalation is also not something you should do casually. It changes relationships, often permanently. Make sure you're doing it for the right reasons and with the evidence to back it up.

### Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Review the escalation indicators: do they apply to your situation?
- [ ] If yes, begin documenting formally now (dates, what was said, witnesses if any)
- [ ] Identify what escalation path makes sense and what support you'd need
- [ ] Consider whether you have sponsors who could help if needed

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## Chapter 12: Recovering Your Confidence After the Damage Is Done

You've done the tactics. You've built the systems. But there's one thing left: the damage that happened to you. The doubt. The questioning. The sense that maybe you don't actually deserve your place.

That damage is real, and it doesn't fix itself automatically.

#### The Psychology of Credit Theft

Credit theft is a form of invalidation. Someone said, through their actions, that your work doesn't belong to you. Your brain, trying to make sense of this, concludes: maybe it doesn't. Maybe I don't deserve credit because I'm not actually valuable.

This is a lie your brain tells to protect you. The logic goes: if I'm not valuable, then it makes sense that my credit was taken. And if it makes sense, then I don't have to feel bad about it. The problem is that this "solution" to the emotional pain creates more pain in the long run—it erodes your confidence at the foundation.

**Rebuilding the Foundation**

Here's what actually works:

**1. Separate performance from recognition**

Your value isn't determined by whether other people acknowledge it. This is hard to accept but essential to internalize. You did good work. That fact exists independently of whether anyone said thank you.

**2. Reclaim the narrative**

The person who took your credit told a story about your work. Tell the true story—to yourself, in your personal log, in conversations with people who know you. The true story is: you did this, it was valuable, and someone misrepresented what happened.

**3. Build competence-based confidence**

Not "people will like me" confidence. Not "I'll be recognized" confidence. Actual competence-based confidence: I know what I'm doing. I've done it before. I can do it again.

Track your wins. Literally. Keep a file of positive feedback, successful outcomes, and moments when your work paid off. Review it when the doubt creeps in.

**4. Find environments where you're seen**

Sometimes the best move isn't to fix the environment that allowed the theft. It's to build a new one. Seek out projects and relationships where your contributions are visible, valued, and acknowledged. Let those experiences rebuild what was damaged.

**5. Consider professional support if the doubt is deep**

If credit theft has left you with persistent self-doubt, imposter syndrome, or anxiety that affects your work, talking to a therapist isn't weakness. It's maintenance. The best professionals I know have coaches or therapists—not because they're broken, but because they take their mental health seriously.

### Action Steps You Can Take Today

- [ ] Write down five concrete examples of work you're genuinely proud of
- [ ] Tell someone (a friend, a mentor, a colleague) about one of those examples
- [ ] Review your Evidence Inventory and let yourself feel proud of what you've accomplished
- [ ] If the doubt is deep, consider reaching out to a therapist or coach this month

#### Key Takeaway for Part Four

The long game is about power and confidence. Build visibility, relationships, and results that make credit theft unlikely. Know when to escalate, and do it strategically. And rebuild your confidence deliberately—because it was never about whether you deserved credit. You always did.

# Conclusion: Putting It All Together

Let's bring this home.

Credit theft is theft. Someone took something that was yours and claimed it as their own. That's wrong, and you don't have to accept it as normal or inevitable.

But you also don't have to lose sleep over it, question your own value, or blow up relationships by responding badly. There's a middle path, and this guide is designed to help you walk it.

### The Four-Part Playbook Recap

1. **Ground yourself first.** Confirm what happened, separate the facts from the doubt, and choose your response strategically—not reactively.

2. **Respond immediately and document thoroughly.** In-the-moment recovery keeps your name in the conversation. Written follow-up creates a record. Strategic non-response is valid when it's actually strategic.

3. **Build systems that prevent it.** Documentation, visibility, and relationships make credit theft harder and your position stronger.

4. **Play the long game.** Shift the power dynamics, know when to escalate, and rebuild your confidence deliberately.

### The Action Checklist: Your Next Step

This guide gives you the framework. The Action Checklist gives you the execution. It's the companion document that walks you through:

- The Credit Audit Worksheet
- The Evidence Inventory
- The Response Decision Matrix
- The Recovery Phrase Bank
- The Follow-Up Email Templates
- The Documentation Checklist
- The Power Equation Assessment
- The Escalation Documentation Guide

Pull out the Action Checklist after you finish reading this. Work through it section by section. It turns everything in this guide into actions you can take today.

### A Final Word

You deserve credit for your work. Not because someone will give it to you, but because you actually did the work. That fact doesn't change based on whether anyone acknowledges it.

Build the systems. Speak up when it's warranted. Let go strategically when it's not. And remember: the doubt you felt after being stolen from was never about you. It was damage from someone else's behavior—and now you have a plan for what to do about it.

Go get the credit you're owed. You've earned it.

### Key Takeaway for the Complete Guide

Credit theft is a solvable problem. Respond in the moment, document your work, build systems that make theft harder, and play the long game with confidence. The goal isn't to catch them—it's to make sure your work is clearly, unmistakably yours. And it is.